

Country Profile: Uruguay

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 2
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholicism
- Official language: None
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Whites/Mestizos

Historical Background

Uruguay, officially the Oriental Republic of Uruguay, gained independence from the Spanish Empire in 1811 as a former part of the Viceroyalty of the Río de la Plata. Occupied by the Portuguese in 1821, the territory was incorporated into the Empire of Brazil and gained recognition as a sovereign state only in 1828, under the Treaty of Montevideo, upon the termination of the Cisplatine War between Brazil and the United Provinces of the Río de la Plata. The state has maintained largely stable borders since then. In the second half of the 20th century, a presidential system of governance was first abolished and later reinstated, followed by a period of authoritarian rule after a 1973 military coup and the restoration of a civilian government in 1985. While the area of present-day Uruguay had historically been populated by Charrúa and Guaraní peoples, hardly any Indigenous communities have remained visible in the state's socioeconomic and political system.

Groups

- **Whites/Mestizos** form the largest racialized group in Uruguay, comprising 90% of the population.¹ Mainly of European origin and descending from mixed marriages with Europeans, they speak the Spanish language.² Most Whites/Mestizos in Uruguay still uphold Roman Catholic beliefs, reflecting the Spanish-influenced past, but significant non-religious communities have formed.³ As Uruguayan

¹ Birnir et al., 2018.

² Ethnologue, 2024.

³ Monreal, 2000; Joshua Project, 2024.

society remains racially stratified, and Whites/Mestizos dominate politics, economy, and culture,⁴ they form the core group of the state.

- **Afro-Uruguayans** are a racialized minority in Uruguay with less than a 10% share of the population, descending from Africans brought to Uruguay during the colonial period and even after independence.⁵ The group largely adopted the Spanish language⁶ and Christian faith, although mainly of Protestant denomination. Despite a widespread belief in the highly inclusive nature of Uruguayan society, as reflected in the country's scores on poverty and inequality indices, it has been suggested that Afro-Uruguayans continue to face severe racial discrimination.⁷

State Profile

Official Language

Uruguay has not developed a clear body of language policies, given the linguistic homogeneity of its population. As such, throughout the second half of the 20th century, Uruguayan constitutions have not established an official language. *De facto*, Spanish is used for administrative purposes.

Official Religion

Roman Catholics not only constitute the largest religious community in Uruguay, but their faith is also mentioned in Article 5 of the Uruguayan constitution: "It recognizes the Catholic Church as the domain of all temples that have been totally or partially built with funds from the National Treasury." However, the preceding sentence in the same article stipulates that "[t]he State does not support any religion," establishing the general principle of separation between church and state. This provision having remained unaltered, no particular belief has enjoyed official recognition by the Uruguayan state.

Education Policies

Uruguay maintains a system of mandatory schooling for children aged 6 to 14, with attendance at public schools being free of charge. Compulsory schooling comprises six

⁴ Scuro et al., 2003; Bormann et al., 2017; Birnir et al., 2018.

⁵ Birnir et al., 2018.

⁶ Bormann et al., 2017.

⁷ Scuro et al., 2003; AFP, 2020.

years of primary schooling and the first phase of middle schooling (two years). This is followed by an optional additional year of lower secondary (middle) school attendance and three optional years of higher secondary school attendance.⁸

Since the Political Constitution of 1934, the Uruguayan primary and secondary education system has been free and egalitarian, without any form of *de jure* segregation. While ethnic diversity is concealed by the state's unitary approach to education, Afro-Uruguayans continue to face structural inequality that is reflected in lower average school performance, for example.⁹ To address these issues, in 2013, the Congress of Uruguay enacted Ley N° 19.122. This law recognizes the existence of institutional racism towards Afro-Uruguayans and implements **affirmative action** measures to facilitate the group's access to higher education through admission quotas for training and qualification programs (Article 5) and scholarship allocation (Article 6).

Language Education Policies

The absence of explicit and coherent language policies in Uruguay is also reflected in the education system, largely due to a lack of need for such regulations.¹⁰ In practice, Spanish—the native language of nearly the entire population—has always been, and remains, the language of instruction in the country's public primary and secondary schools.

Religious Education Policies

No denominational religious education takes place in Uruguay's schools. Religious instruction in public schools was first prohibited in 1909. Despite constitutional amendments and changes to the laws governing schooling, public education has remained secular since then.¹¹ The principle of *laicidad* (secularity) was most recently reaffirmed in Article 15 of the 2008 General Education Law, Ley N° 18.437.

Private schools have not faced restrictions, and the constitutional guarantee of the freedom of education under Article 59 provides the basis for their operation to date.

⁸ Scholaro, 2025.

⁹ Rodríguez, 2022, 308.

¹⁰ L'Aménagement linguistique dans le monde, 2020.

¹¹ Religlaw Database, 2024; Iralde, 2023.

Constitutions and Laws

The constitution of Uruguay was first adopted in 1830 upon the establishment of Uruguay as an independent state. In the second half of the 20th century, it was subject to several major amendments. Also called the “Third Constitution,” the 1934 Amendment of the Constitution of Uruguay abolished the collegial executive system that had been implemented three decades before and transferred executive powers back to the president. The amended constitution did not make any explicit reference to a particular ethnic identity. Furthermore, while establishing the separation of church and state, despite recognizing the presence of Catholicism, Article 5.1 of the new text guaranteed universal religious liberties, stating that “[a]ll religions may be freely practiced in Uruguay.” Subsequent amendments and constitutions left key principles largely unchanged.

Citizenship Laws

Implementing a broad interpretation of the *jus soli* principle, the Constitution of Uruguay guarantees unconditional birthright citizenship to anyone born within the state. As per Article 74 of the most recent version of the text, “[a]ll men and women born at any place within the territory of the Republic are natural citizens.” This regime has largely remained unchanged throughout the observed time period.

National Anthem(s)

The Uruguayan national anthem, unofficially titled “Orientales, la Patria o la tumba” [Uruguayans, the Fatherland or the Grave], was written by Francisco Esteban Acuña de Figueroa following the state’s independence. It was officially adopted in 1833, with the final version debuting in 1845.¹² A typical Latin American epic anthem, it depicts the state’s struggle and desire for independence, spattered with references to martyrdom in expressions describing the will to achieve “[f]reedom or die with glory”. Furthermore, military references are used to characterize the illustrations of “fierce battles” fought to achieve sovereign statehood.

¹² Nationalanthems.info, 2024.

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